Between the Star and the Street – A Collection

By Jonathan B. Tucker and Nour Abdel Latif

INTRODUCTION

The following 3 poems live in the raw space between Jewish identity and Palestinian suffering -- where shared history collides with unequal power and unresolved grief. They trace how a symbol like the Star of David can become a source of shame, how Gaza exists not as a headline but as a place of memory, and how voices rooted in truth can come to be treated as threats.

*What happens when survival hardens into domination? What happens when inherited trauma is used to justify present violence? I urge you to listen with an open mind and to recognize **both** sides of a conflict where human lives are too often erased in the name of history.*

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Dear David by Jonathan B. Tucker

(Pgs 4-8) A six-sided star fishes for identity on my chest

Tucked under a mixed family

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It dangles like a worm on a hook under American waters

David, you've become a constellation we no longer strain to see

Like a king's crown

Your yellow light showed us through the darkest times

Exposed us to the darkest crimes

When you labeled us a problem

A question

They answered with genocide

Another problem

Another question

They answered with atomic bombs

More problems

We stop asking

And instead promise never again

We lie

Dead

As our babies

Boom

Might as well drop them out of the planes

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Makes as much sense as cartoons as war propaganda

Dear David
They gave you a nation but what did you say?
Are you trapped between those two blue bars or can you still get away?
Because Israel was dropped on top of Palestine and is there to stay
Like one triangle
Turned around and dropped on another
You see, David, my brother cannot be anti-Semitic if he is as Semitic as me
Isaac, Ishmael just wants to be free
But you've got him building pyramids out of the charred dust of bulldozed homes
In the Gaza
Stripped of rights
You've let your brother sleep naked and hungry too many nights

You pharaoh
Cashing checks from the West
Bank

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You've become
Settled
In your thinking
Unlike your Torah
You do not move
You have not turned

You six-sided sinner
You blind Goliath
You have a hexagon center that points nowhere but inward
What are you looking for out in that desert?
Is it another ghetto?
Are you somehow jealous of the swastika's popularity among disaffected youth?
I mean, are you trying to be a bad a**?
Or are you just an abused child
Now grown up
Molesting your nephew and calling him names?

Dear David
Our homeland is neither
Just like the Christian Right. . . . How ashamed you've

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made us

I used to cover all my notebooks with little pictures of you

Now I tuck you under my shirt in order to hide my association with

My role in unwillingly supporting your racial, national, religious apartheid

You make me sick

David

Oceans away

You fish for identity on my chest

Reminding me who I am

Because of how you can't be

Reminding me where I come from

By showing us where we can't go

You are a fallen star

Not lucky

Nor bright

Yet I still see myself in you far too often

Like some birthright trip to hypocrisy

From Crofton, Maryland

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Because all I can say

Is never again

As I tuck my necklace away

And pray that we end this oppression

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jonathan B Tucker *
Book: Speaking Truths: Young Adults, Identity, and Spoken Word Activism by Valerie Chepp, Pgs 4-8
ISBN: 978-1978801103
Publisher: Rutgers University Press
Date (Month/Year): Feb 2022

** Jonathan B. Tucker, foundation relations manager at Refugees International, was born in Washington, D.C. Prior to joining Refugees International, Tucker served as the director of youth programs at Split This Rock, where he taught and coached the award-winning DC Youth Poetry Slam Team and co-founded the Louder Than a Bomb DMV Teen Poetry Slam Festival.*

Between Here and Gone by Nour Abdel Latif

How can I press a city to my chest?

Embrace its streets, its homes, its windows?

How can my heart stretch wide,

To hold a longing this deep?

And how can I kiss its wounded ground,

Without my soul collapsing?

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How do I hold a scream so deep,

In the alley where I used to play?

How do I wipe a silent tear,

On the stone where Dad once sat?

How do I bring our laughs once more,

To streets we knew?

And how do I say, I missed you so,

Without letting the heartbreak show?

How do I mend my shadow on her timeworn stone,

Where every crack once knew me as its own?

How do I walk the same streets of my young feet,

Without the weight of all that's lost, replayed?

How do I hear the rising call to prayer,

And not let tears betray my hidden cries?

How do I say, I had to go away,

When my soul never left?

Gaza...

How can one hug hold all your scattered cries?

How can my heart survive the loss each time your

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name goes by?

I walk your streets, yet I'm not there,

I search your face—it's lost.

You break inside me,

Without a reason I know why.

Gaza still stands—but not the same,

A shadow walks where once burned flame.

And the ache left within my chest

Is deeper, harsher—

A grief beyond a single death.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nour Abdel Latif *
ISBN: On-Line Transcript
https://newyorkwarcrimes.com/if-i-must-starve
Publisher: New York War Crimes.com
Date (Month/Year): Oct 6, 2026

* *Nour Abdel Latif is a mother of three and a writer who lived in North Gaza until repeated displacements forced her to move south. Her work, which includes both poetry and personal diaries, provides a firsthand account of the war, the destruction of her home and business, and the challenges of survival and displacement in Gaza*

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Buried Truths, Rising Voices by Nour Abdel Latif

*For all the blue vests killed in Gaza **

It resembled us—
that voice, grown from our anguish,
carrying pain washed clean by dew,
telling our stories with unheard tone,
as if he spoke from behind a soundproof glass.

A voice of ours, born of our wounds,
steady as dawn on Gaza's brow,
like a sea resisting the blade of fate,
like a field of anemones in spring's gentle glow—
Full of longing, even as it fades.

It was just a voice.
No weapon in hand, no blood on its breath,
just a melody,
perhaps borne by the wind beyond the edge,
or a whisper
that reached the hearts of those who were numb to
the truth.

Why did they silence it?
Was it because it looked like us?
Because he loved the land
as if his soul were forged in her dust?

Yes, it was a voice,
a light from the heart when the sky turns black,
illuminating ruin, gifting breath to hope—
and so, they feared it
and buried it beneath the ground—without a tear,
without even a tremble.

But a voice born of truth
is never laid to rest.
It lingers—
in the dust, in the wind,
in every heartbeat that dares to remember.
One day, it will rise again—
not as a whisper,
but as a storm.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nour Abdel Latif
ISBN: On-Line Transcript
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***** *As of August 2005, more than 270 journalists and media workers (blue vests) have been killed by Israeli attacks in Gaza. Read more here: https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2025/8/11/here-are-the-names-of-the-journalists-israel-killed-in-gaza*

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